

Check it out. And, by the way, we know this is not the first time you have done this. \$%%#@, you watch out, we will make you pay for this dearly.'

I was at a loss for words, and that left them in no doubt whatsoever about my culpability. Then PS stepped closer to me. 'Kid, you are from Dombivli, aren't you? I have heard the trains on that route are quite crowded . . . ' and then, his voice dropping to a whisper, he went on, ' . . . and people regularly lose their limbs or lives falling off packed trains.'

This time they had rattled me well and good. I stood rooted there for nearly a minute after the duo had left. My hands were trembling, and I instinctively thrust them into my pockets to not let them show. I reflected on what they, especially PS, had said. Perhaps it was a spontaneous outburst arising from wounded pride at being outsmarted. Yet, knowing their uncouth ways, I was worried that they would go to any extent to settle scores. After all, how much would it cost to hire two goons to fix me in Dombivli itself, and make it look like a street brawl or a mugging attempt gone awry?

I had friends in the market, but none in whom I could confide my inner fears. I had half a mind to complain about the duo to the authorities in the exchange. But I saw little point in doing that since these two rogues were quite influential. More worryingly, I could not complain without running the risk of my misdeeds being exposed. There was a real chance that they would carry out their threat of causing me physical harm. At the same time, I did not want to give them the impression that I was beaten. So, in the following settlement, I undercut them in two stocks, but chose those which did not cause either AS or PS a huge loss. I steered clear of the large offers in which they were involved.

For the next couple of months, I would take a good look around before boarding or getting off the train. I also made it a point to position myself away from the footboard except while boarding or alighting.

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AS and PS would try to finger me whenever they could. I had become competent at sourcing decent lots of stocks. So if I bought a certain number of shares of company X on the floor, I knew which broker would be interested in buying that lot, and would accordingly strike a deal to sell the shares to him at the earliest. Similarly, if I had sold stock Y, I knew which